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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours)/MGU-BBA (Honours)/MGU-BCA (Honours) Special Examinations, July 2026 (for 2024 Admission Regular Examinations, October 2025)

THIRD SEMESTER

Value Addition Course (VAC) - MG3VACHIS200 - IDEA OF INDIA

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

ANSWER KEY

Part A
SHORT ANSWER
Answer any 5 questions
Each question carries 2 marks

1) Varna-based division of labour rationalised early administrative hierarchy- Brahmins as scribes and revenue officials- hereditary occupational castes (Kayasthas, Nairs) monopolised clerical functions- continuity under colonial rule through 'martial races' and 'writer caste' recruitment policies- reinforced structural exclusion of lower castes from bureaucratic power- reservation policy after independence as a corrective for representative bureaucracy.

2) Tank irrigation under the Cholas and Vijayanagara rulers- state's role in resource mobilisation and revenue extraction tied to water control- Burton Stein's segmentary state thesis reads this as ritual sovereignty rather than centralised administrative control- local *nadu* assemblies and temples managed tank maintenance- hydraulic despotism model-reflects negotiated, decentralised authority rather than an all-powerful centre.

3) Amartya Sen's argumentative tradition- Buddhist councils and Ashokan dhamma edicts as early instances of public reasoning- Charvaka and other heterodox schools challenging Brahminical ritual authority- Bhakti-Sufi dialogues widening notions of equality before the divine- debate as the space where ideas of fairness were contested rather than fixed-justice thus shown as historically negotiated, not a static Brahminical inheritance.

4) Impact of the 1917 Russian Revolution and Comintern support- Tashkent group led by M. N. Roy from 1920- disillusionment with Gandhian non-violence after the Chauri Chaura withdrawal (1922)- radicalisation of trade union and peasant movements- formal founding at the Kanpur Conference of 1925- early leadership including S. A. Dange and Muzaffar Ahmad- colonial repression through the Kanpur and Meerut Conspiracy Cases.

5) Reform movements (Brahmo Samaj, Arya Samaj, Self-Respect Movement) supplied the vocabulary of rights, equality and rationalism later absorbed into nationalist discourse-tension between reformists like Gokhale (reform before self-rule) and nationalists like Tilak (political freedom first)- Ambedkar's warning that political democracy without

social democracy is a hollow achievement- reform and nationalism mutually reinforcing yet frequently in conflict over priority.

6) Chairman of the Constitution's Drafting Committee (1947-49)- shaped the architecture of fundamental rights and directive principles- Article 17 abolishing untouchability- constitutional safeguards and reservations for Scheduled Castes and Tribes- synthesised parliamentary democracy with a programme of social revolution- viewed law as an instrument of social transformation, not merely procedure.

7) Discovery of India (1946) as ideological blueprint- Five Year Plans and a mixed economy conceived as the route to substantive, not merely formal, democracy- planning as scientific temper applied to nation-building- Parekh's reading of Nehru's national philosophy- underlying tension between centralised planning and democratic pluralism- economic self-reliance treated as a precondition for genuine political freedom.

8) Idea of 'principled distance'- the state neither wholly separates from nor establishes any religion- can intervene to reform religious practice (Articles 25-30, Shirur Mutt case, 1954)- equal respect for all faiths rather than a strict wall of separation as in the western model- allows accommodation of India's religious plurality while restraining majoritarian dominance- remains contested amid rising communal polarisation.

Part B
SHORT ESSAY
Answer any 4 questions
Each question carries 5 marks

9) 73rd and 74th Amendments introducing one-third reservation in panchayats- numerical presence has risen- yet the proxy control by male relatives in practice- descriptive representation does not automatically translate into substantive power- persistent wage gaps, domestic burdens and patriarchal party structures continue to limit real influence- representation is necessary but insufficient without deeper structural change.

10) Cultural nationalism conflates the nation with a single dominant culture or religion, eroding India's plurality- the Hindutva strand privileges an upper-caste Hindu idiom as the 'authentic' national culture- risks excluding Muslims, Christians, Dalits and Adivasis from full civilisational belonging- stands in contrast to the pluralist, civic nationalism of Nehru and Tagore- G. Aloysius's 'Nationalism without a Nation'- Guha's 'Enemies of the Idea of India'- carries the danger of majoritarian homogenisation rather than genuine unity in diversity.

11) Constitutional safeguards under Articles 25-30, personal laws and minority educational institutions- some gains: minority commissions, protections for religious and linguistic minorities- persistent failures: communal violence around Partition, the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, the 2002 Gujarat riots- rise of majoritarian politics and hate speech in recent decades- overall record mixed, with constitutional promise repeatedly undercut by political practice.

12) The Emergency of 1975-77 as the paradigmatic case- suspension of civil liberties and press censorship- preventive detention under MISA- pressure on and supersession within the judiciary- coercive programmes such as forced sterilisation and slum clearance- long-

term consequences in the 42nd and 44th Amendments, a weakened federal balance, and eroded public trust- shows how executive overreach corrodes checks and balances even within a formally democratic constitution.

13) Ambedkar's Annihilation of Caste- caste theorised as graded inequality embedded within the Hindu social order, not merely a division of labour- rejection of reformist Hinduism, culminating in conversion to Buddhism- Periyar's Self-Respect Movement offering a rationalist, atheist critique of Brahminical ritual authority and Puranic mythology- both moved the meaning of equality beyond formal legal rights toward the social annihilation of hierarchy- Guru's account of nationalism as a framework for Dalit self-realisation- Pandian on Periyar's 'denationalising' critique- equality redefined as structural rather than merely constitutional.

14) Lohia criticised Nehruvian planning as bureaucratic, elite-driven and inattentive to caste- also criticised Soviet-style communism as dogmatic and blind to Indian social realities, privileging class over caste- advocated decentralised socialism, the '*Sapta Kranti*' programme, mobilisation of backward castes, and anti-English language politics- limited electoral success within his own lifetime- lasting ideological legacy in backward-caste politics and the later Mandal-era coalitions- offered a genuinely indigenous socialist alternative, though organisationally fragmented.

15) Muziris, Surat, and the Malabar and Coromandel ports as nodes of Indian Ocean trade- cosmopolitan mercantile communities including Arab, Jewish, Chinese and Southeast Asian traders- Islam's early diffusion along the Malabar coast through trade rather than conquest- Buddhism's spread to Southeast Asia via maritime routes- coastal cities functioning as contact zones that fostered religious and cultural syncretism- distinct from the inland, agrarian, Brahminical-dominated zones- a maritime identity that was plural, mercantile, and outward-looking.

Part C
ESSAY QUESTION
Answer any 2 questions
Each question carries 10 marks

16) Agarwal's 'Who is Bharat Mata?'- Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's Vande Mataram in Anandamath (1882) first fused the motherland with goddess imagery- Abanindranath Tagore's 1905 painting, produced during the Swadeshi movement, gave the figure visual form- syncretism of Devi/Durga iconography with the cartographic map of India- served to evoke emotional and devotional attachment to the nation and helped mobilise anti-colonial sentiment- functions as a form of sacred geography in Diana Eck's sense- critiqued for Hindu-centric imagery that risked excluding Muslims and other minorities from the national imaginary- the symbol remains contested in secular-nationalist debates today, illustrating the tension between religious idiom and inclusive nationhood.

17) Bhakti-Sufi interactions, as discussed by Satish Chandra, generated shared devotional idioms across communities- royal and temple patronage financed artisans, musicians and architects- Indo-Islamic architecture in the Gujarat Sultanate and Deccan courts blended temple and mosque forms- pilgrimage circuits linking Sufi dargahs and Hindu tirthas sustained syncretic performance traditions such as qawwali and folk devotional music- expanding trade networks and urban markets provided artisan guilds with an economic

base beyond royal patronage alone- hybrid art thus emerged from the intersection of economic, devotional and political patronage rather than any single 'pure' tradition- demonstrates the plural, negotiated cultural production characteristic of medieval India's eclecticism.

18) Mainstream cinema and television have often reproduced upper-caste normativity- protagonists are typically upper-caste by default, with caste rarely named explicitly, the *savarna* as unmarked pattern- lower-caste characters are frequently confined to servile or comic roles- folk performance and regional cinema have increasingly offered counter-narratives- Dalit assertion in literature and film, including Ambedkarite cultural production and films addressing caste violence directly- OTT platforms have enabled more explicit caste narratives in recent years- the overall pattern is mixed: dominant commercial culture tends to reproduce stereotypes while alternative, activist-driven cultural forms increasingly challenge them- popular culture thus remains a contested terrain rather than a uniformly reproductive or transformative one.

19) Critique of colonial economic exploitation- the drain of wealth, deindustrialisation, and denial of self-determination- Bose was simultaneously critical of India's own conservative social order, including caste rigidity, communal division and passive acceptance of British rule as obstacles to national regeneration- the Forward Bloc (1939) envisioned state-led industrialisation and socialist planning as instruments of modernisation- the Indian National Army and Azad Hind government embodied a secular, disciplined organisation cutting across caste and religious lines- the Rani of Jhansi Regiment reflected a commitment to women's mobilisation- Bose fused anti-imperialism with anti-conservatism, seeking a modern, egalitarian, though authoritarian-leaning, post-colonial state distinct from both Gandhian gradualism and Nehruvian parliamentary socialism.